

Meet an unfamiliar move with questions

Opening Decisions

THE IDEA

An unusual opening move need not be refuted immediately. Identify what it attacks, what it neglects, and what squares it weakens. A sound developing move may be the best answer if no tactic exists.

WORKED EXAMPLE

After an early flank pawn move, check whether your central pawn advance gains space safely. Do not launch a speculative sacrifice merely because the opponent left your memorized line. Their move may be playable but slightly slow.

TRY IT BEFORE READING ON

What should replace memory when the book line ends?

ANSWER AND REASONING

Use king safety, development, central control, and calculation of immediate threats. These criteria remain available in every opening, including positions you have never seen.

TAKE THIS INTO YOUR NEXT GAME

Treat surprise as a position to assess, not a demand to punish.